

Work and Identity in an Era of Precarious Employment: How Workers Respond to “Personal Branding” Discourse

Work and Occupations

2018, Vol. 45(1) 3–37

© The Author(s) 2017

Reprints and permissions:

sagepub.com/journalsPermissions.nav

DOI: 10.1177/0730888417735662

journals.sagepub.com/home/wox

Steven P. Vallas¹ and Angèle Christin²

Abstract

Recent efforts to understand the significance of precarious work have been limited in at least two important respects. One is the neglect of the ideological constructs that workers are led to embrace concerning the employment relation, and the other is the undertheorized nature of much research in this field. To address these limits, the authors adopt a two-pronged strategy in this article. In empirical terms, the authors focus on an important source of popular thinking about work: the career advice genre, which has recently evolved into a growing literature on “personal branding.” In theoretical terms, the authors appeal to Foucault’s theory of governmentality in order to understand how and why workers respond to personal branding discourses. Data are drawn from two linked qualitative studies bearing on workers employed in distinct settings: freelance journalists in Paris and New York ($N = 101$) and a broader set of white-collar employees who have faced market adversity in Boston ($N = 62$). Findings reveal that personal branding discourse has become both prevalent and potent, encouraging many workers to conform to what Foucault referred

¹Northeastern University, Boston, MA, USA

²Stanford University, Stanford, CA, USA

Corresponding Author:

Steven P. Vallas, Northeastern University, 360 Huntington Avenue, 958 Renaissance Park, Boston, MA 02115, USA.

Email: s.vallas@neu.edu

to as the “enterprising self.” Yet the authors also find that workers respond to personal branding in a multiplicity of ways, some of which Foucault left unaddressed. The article thus finds qualified support for Foucault’s arguments but identifies issues—especially that of agency and resistance—which stand in need of additional elaboration.

Keywords

precarious work, personal branding, economic discourse, neoliberalism, Foucault

The decline of “standard” work arrangements has attracted much scholarly attention in recent years (Kalleberg, 2011; Kalleberg & Vallas, 2017; Smith, 2001, 2010), greatly enriching our understanding of the myriad ways in which employment relations are being transformed. Scholars have focused particular attention on the structural determinants of this precarization trend, such as the erosion of union strength (Locke & Thelen, 1995; Western & Rosenfeld, 2011), the heightened mobility of capital (Bronfenbrenner & Luce, 2004; Collins, 2003), the digital revolution (Schor, Fitzmaurice, Attwood-Charles, Carfagna, & Poteat, 2016), and the rise of the “shareholder conception” of the firm (Fligstein & Shin, 2007; Ho, 2009a, 2009b). Yet relatively little attention has been paid to the specifically ideological constructs that workers encounter as they formulate conceptions of the employment relation and of their own identities as employees (see Lamont, Beljean, & Clair, 2014; for an exception, see Boltanski & Chiapello, 2005). This gap has hampered our ability to understand the forces that may legitimate the decline of the “standard” work arrangement and can encourage workers to consent to their growing exposure to labor market uncertainty.

A second absence in the literature on precarious work, bound up with the first, regards the relatively undertheorized state of our knowledge regarding this historical trend. To be sure, there is no shortage of ambitious theorizing about the growth of precarity as a feature of social and economic life. Such major thinkers as Giddens (1991), Bauman (2000), and Beck (1992, 2000) have all made the question of precarity a central theme of their respective analyses of late modernity. Yet relatively little of this theorizing has been brought to bear on concrete empirical research. Indeed, much of the U.S.-based literature on precarious work has fallen into one of two camps: national-level quantitative

studies of trends affecting job insecurity and labor market conditions (Hollister, 2011; Kalleberg, 2009, 2011; Katz & Krueger, 2016) or focused case studies of particular occupations or industries (Lane, 2011; Pugh, 2015; Sharone, 2014). With some exceptions (Ho, 2009b), the literature on precarious work has exhibited great strength empirically but a relative weakness theoretically. This has made it difficult to determine whether the exposure of workers to precarious labor market conditions represents part of a Polanyian double movement (see Kalleberg, 2009) or the onset of an entirely new stage of modernity, such as the “end of organized capitalism” (see Kalleberg & Vallas, 2017; Lash & Urry, 1987).

In this article, we address both these gaps in the literature on precarious work. First, to capture the role played by the ideological influences to which workers are exposed, we focus on one relatively neglected phenomenon: the career advice genre (see Biggart, 1983). Specifically, we analyze one specific off-shoot of career advice literature: The phenomenon of personal branding, which has become a pervasive feature of lay discussions about job seeking and career development since the late 1990s (Gershon, 2011; Marwick, 2013; Pagis & Ailon, 2017; Vallas & Cummins, 2015; Wee & Brooks, 2010). Now manifest not only in books and magazines but also blogs, social media, and in-person workshops, personal branding discourse invites workers and job seekers to rethink their dependence on bureaucratic employment as an economic platform, and instead to view themselves as profit-seeking enterprises that can best succeed by applying corporate marketing strategies to their face-to-face and online interactions. Using interview data collected from workers employed in distinct occupational contexts, we ask: How do job seekers and workers react to the discourse of personal branding as a species of entrepreneurial talk? And which social factors seem to shape their likelihood of consenting to this discourse?

Second, we rely on one strand of contemporary theorizing that has yet to be fully incorporated within the mainstream lexicon of economic sociology: Foucauldian theories of governmentality, which we argue are particularly well suited to address the role of ideology and discourse in shaping popular thinking about employment and economic institutions more generally (du Gay, 1996; Foucault, 2008; McNay, 2009). Foucault was among the first social scientists to acknowledge the cultural significance of neoliberal doctrines, arguing that modernity increasingly fosters the rise of what he termed the “enterprising self” as form of subjectivity that aligns with market needs. Yet Foucault’s work has received a wary posture from most American sociologists studying

work. We find that this has limited the growth of knowledge in two important respects. First, it has deprived sociologists of work of potentially important theoretical tools with which to understand subtle yet important shifts in the meanings that work and employment assume within the contemporary setting. In addition, sociological neglect of Foucauldian theory has denied the latter the opportunity to extend, revise, or refine its theoretical claims on the basis of empirical research.

To ground our analysis empirically, we conjoin qualitative data gathered from two projects utilizing distinct yet complementary research designs. The first project focused specifically on freelance web journalists in Paris and New York, whose careers hinge on their success at audience promotion. The second focuses on precariously employed white-collar workers and job seekers in multiple occupations, all residing in or near the Boston metropolitan area. The first project holds occupation constant (all interviewees are practicing journalists) but allows geographical location to vary (France and United States); the second project manifests the opposite set of features, holding geographical location constant while allowing occupation to vary. This comparative approach in turn provides the basis for a wider set of findings than would otherwise be possible.

The article begins by introducing the main tenets of the Foucauldian theory of governmentality, outlining how its conceptual framework can inform research on work and employee identity. It then turns to a discussion of “personal branding,” an entrepreneurial turn in the career advice literature that has begun to exert broad influence over many of the norms and assumptions that govern paid employment in precarious times. After sketching the methods and research strategies that have guided our data collection, the article next presents the views of personal branding discourse held by freelance journalists in Paris and New York and by precariously employed white-collar workers in Boston. We find that the predominant response to personal branding is one of consent or conformity to its terms, and thus a tendency for workers and job seekers to embrace an increasingly commercialized conception of self. This response, we find, bears a close resemblance to Foucault’s notion of the “enterprising self.” Yet we also find other, more defiant responses to self-branding rhetoric—that is, forms of resistance—which seem to depend on several institutional features experienced by workers during the course of their careers, including national context, occupational norms, and labor market trajectory. The article concludes that Foucauldian approaches toward work, employment, and subjectivity hold substantial promise for sociological analysis, but that they stand

in need of further theoretical and empirical refinement, particularly with respect to the question of worker agency and resistance to neoliberal forms of economic activity. The article closes by sketching fruitful lines of future research on work, entrepreneurial discourse, and the commercialization of the self in late modernity.

Economic Discourse and the Worker's Soul

Although he was trained as a philosopher, Michel Foucault's (1978, 1979, 2008) work pursued fundamentally sociological questions throughout the course of his career, blending theoretical analysis with concrete historical studies of the systems of mentality that underpinned the exercise of power and authority during the rise of modernity. In some respects, Foucault's work can be viewed as an effort to modernize and deepen Weber's theory of legitimate domination.¹ Yet American sociologists have tended to view Foucault as a thinker whose work does not lend itself to empirical research. We argue that this view is overly narrow and short sighted, in that it deprives sociological thinking of important theoretical resources with which to understand how cultural or discursive constructs are bound up with the processes that foster institutional change. Decades before the term "neoliberalism" came into common usage, Foucault sensed that neoliberal economic discourse was likely to figure prominently in the exercise of power over human subjectivity during the latter part of the 20th century (see Foucault, 1979, 2008). He also developed a highly original interpretation of human capital theory that is sharply distinct from that adopted by sociologists of work and organizations (Vallas & Hill, 2012). In what follows we offer a brief sketch of Foucault's theory of governmentality and the insights it provides, on which our empirical analysis will draw.

From his earliest studies, Foucault's work was concerned with the linkages among power, knowledge, and the predominant forms that human subjectivity assumed within particular historical periods. In this spirit, he developed a series of influential historical accounts of the definition and treatment of madness, sickness, criminality, and sexual difference (Foucault, 1978, 1979, 1988). One important theme in much of his work was an effort to show the historical connections (or genealogies) that united particular rituals or practices, such as the Christian ritual of confession and the modern practices of therapy or the examination (Foucault, 1993). Toward the latter stages of his life, he adopted a more comprehensive approach toward power, knowledge,

and subjectivity, eventuating in his widely influential theory of governmentality (Behrent, 2016; Burchell, 1996; Gordon, 1991; Lemke, 2001; McNay, 2009). Moving beyond his earlier stress on the trend toward “disciplinary” rule—the highly rationalized system of authority relations discussed in *Discipline and Punish* (1979)—and responding to criticism that he had not sufficiently taken into account the role of the state, Foucault began to explore the normative apparatuses (*dispositifs*) that characterized the exercise of power over civil society throughout Western history.

This line of thinking emerged from Foucault’s interest in Greek culture and institutions, during the course of which he was struck by the diffuse manner in which the term “governance” was used in ancient Greece. Thus, the Greeks commonly spoke of the need to govern not only the *polis* but also one’s estate (*oikos*), one’s family, one’s appetites, and especially one’s self. With the rise of Christianity, there arose a conception of the self as harboring deep-lying truths that could only be identified through acts of subordination to one’s confessor (Foucault, 1993). Then, as the Western nation-state grew in size, and scale and rulers sought to develop appropriate “arts of governing,” they relied on a form of political rationality that Foucault (2007, 2008) termed “pastoral” power. Here, partly reflecting the example of the Church, sovereign rulers exercised power over their subjects using categories modeled on the notion of the shepherd overlooking and defending his flock. With the rise of modernity, however, this model proved insufficient, and sovereign power was increasingly compelled to rely on the human sciences (public health, demography, penology, and psychiatry), thus spawning a model of sociopolitical rule that shifted power downward into the institutions of civil society. Over time, “governmentality” transcended pastoral power, enabling the state to inscribe normative apparatuses across the social landscape, institutionalizing social control in ways that reached far beneath and below political apparatuses themselves.

Three changes are notable with this shift toward governmentality. First, the family no longer provides a *model* of government but instead becomes its *instrument*. Institutionalized relationships begin to serve as technologies of social control, with the state conducting norms from above (Foucault refers to the “conduct of conduct”). This presses the exercise of power down into the “capillary levels” of the social body, undergirding the exercise of state power from below. Second, a more fully rationalized form of control takes shape that concerns itself with the well-being of whole populations, using statistical measures of public

health, fertility, longevity, and productivity. Here, formal knowledge and expertise enable elites to manage whole populations through behavioral norms deemed suitable toward this end. Third, and of particular importance, Foucault stresses the growing centrality of economic discourse as a human science, which he believed would serve to reshape the nature and exercise of governmental power within Western capitalism.

In his lectures of 1978 to 1979, Foucault (2008) became particularly interested in the significance of human capital theory, which he viewed not as a doctrine to be tested or refuted empirically—the approach commonly adopted among sociologists of work organizations—but rather as a sign of a broader cultural shift that was destined to envelop the social and political order writ large. Precisely because human capital theory conjured the individual actor as an economic enterprise in his or her own right, it embodied a set of principles that Foucault believed would gain increasing purchase over human conduct as modernity unfolded. In his view, governmental power increasingly rests on the articulation of institutional arrangements premised on the neoliberal conception of *homo economicus*, an ideal-type form of subjectivity whose agents are endowed with the freedom and responsibility of creating and recreating their own value within the marketplace.

Several themes emerge from this turn in Foucault's thinking. For one thing, he argues that the exercise of power in the contemporary world has come to rely on subtle yet important "technologies of the self"—micropolitical rituals and practices that conjure particular forms of subjectivity, much as was presaged in the Christian ritual of the confession. These technologies serve important political and ideological functions, chiefly by aligning forms of subjectivity with the needs of the neoliberal economy. A second, related theme is Foucault's insistence that power has changed its apparent logic. Rather than operating negatively, through *subtraction*—that is, through a logic of denial, coercion, or discipline—power now operates through far more positive or affirmative mechanisms: It rules by seeming to *multiply* the opportunities and choices that individual actors can enjoy. As Foucault (1978) writes, power is increasingly "organized around the management of life rather than the menace of death" (p. 147).

Third, and most importantly, a regime of selfhood emerges in which workers are encouraged to become "entrepreneurs of themselves." Rather than the mere "partner of exchange" central to classical liberal economics, neoliberalism expects the worker to become an "entrepreneur of himself, being for himself his own capital, being for himself his own producer, being for himself the source of his earnings"

(Foucault, 2008, p. 226). In this view, what the dominant institutions produce is not docile or compliant subjects, but rather self-producing subjects: individuals who take responsibility for working on themselves, for enhancing their own value-creating qualities, and for willingly engaging in productivity-generating activities. What results is a neoliberalizing trend that is both broad and deep: broad, in that it spreads across a wide array of social and cultural institutions; and deep, because those practices that were once specific to economic firms are increasingly applied to the individual self. As a result, Foucault (2008) argues, “the individual’s life itself” is reconstrued as “a sort of permanent and multiple enterprise” (p. 241).

This brief presentation brings into view some of the distinctive strengths that Foucauldian analysis stands to offer to economic sociology and the sociology of work. Where some scholars focus on the structural arrangements that account for recent shifts in economic institutions, Foucault insists that culture and discourses cannot be viewed as either residual influences or as individual-level attitudes. Instead, the entrepreneurial ideology that now predominates—and the normative discourses and conceptions of the self that come with it—have a productive effect on their own, in that they create the kinds of individuals needed to function in a precarious economy. Following his analysis, it becomes crucial to identify the micropolitical rituals and technologies of the self through which given forms of subjectivity are produced. Implied here is Foucault’s (1979) insistence on viewing the self as a political construct i.e., as an “effect of certain types of power” (p. 29).

At the same time, it is important to acknowledge certain absences and ambiguities within the Foucauldian corpus. One involves the role of agency and resistance. Although Foucault (2007) authored cogent accounts of what he called “counter-conduct,” (pp. 190–226), these concerned late medieval religious movements whose relation to contemporary societies remains unclear (see Davidson, 2007; Foucault, 1982). In his later work, Foucault addressed the possible “reversibility” of institutionalized forms of power, and spoke of instances of truth telling or “veridiction,” but he seldom specified their conditions of possibility—that is, the structural and cultural resources that counter-conduct presupposed (Knights, 2016; Thompson & Ackroyd, 1995). Mindful of this point, scholars such as Collinson (2003) have sought to develop a more articulated conception of “subjectivity in practice,” acknowledging that *multiple* forms of selfhood can emerge in response to neoliberal uncertainty. In this view, some workers may exhibit

“conformist” selves, akin to *homo economicus*, which willingly embrace the norms that constitute the enterprising self. Others may adopt neoliberal practices but in a purely strategic manner (what Collinson labels “dramaturgical selves”). Still others may conceivably refuse or resist the marketization of the self (“resistant selves,” in Collinson’s framework). Hence, a fuller conception of agency and resistance is needed than Foucault himself provides.

A parallel problem is the relative absence in Foucauldian thought of any comparative perspective toward sociohistorical change. Foucault’s work usually sought to identify broad historical trends that engulfed Western modernity as a whole. Yet this stance at times led him overlook sharp variations across particular nation states.² Not surprisingly, Foucauldian approaches toward neoliberalism have only rarely adopted a comparative approach. Yet scholars have showed that neoliberalism has unfolded in a highly uneven manner, given variations in the structural arrangements and cultural repertoires that characterize social collectivities at various levels of analysis, including occupational communities or national contexts (Lamont & Thevenot, 2000; Mijs, Bakhtiari, & Lamont, 2016; Peck, 2010; Weber, 2000). Here too one finds need for refinement of the Foucauldian approach.

The Entrepreneurial Turn: Career Advice and the Rise of “Personal Branding”

To explore workers’ responses to precarization and address the limitations of the Foucauldian framework in terms of agency and resistance, this article focuses on the case of personal branding discourse, an important extension of the career advice genre. Although this latter phenomenon has only occasionally been the object of social scientific analysis (Biggart, 1983), it provides a well-identified body of thought that serves to establish legitimate ways of being and thinking among many employees, job seekers, students, and other participants in the labor force.

Career advice literature has a long history (McGee, 2005) but the modern era is often said to begin with the publication of Richard Bolles’s *What Color is Your Parachute*, written in the late 1970s (see McGee, 2005), stressing the importance of self-discovery and the pursuit of one’s passions as the guiding principle for one’s career. By the 1990s, this literature had begun to exhibit influences stemming from the wider development of what some have called “brand” or “promotional

culture” (Wernick, 1991). The notion here is that brand management has assumed an ever-greater economic significance, affecting the “reputational capital” of not only capitalist enterprises but also universities, cities, hospitals, and nation states. As executives at Nike or Starbucks well understand, achieving success in the marketplace requires that firms imbue their products with symbolic meanings of the sort that Marx’s commodity fetishism only began to describe (Jameson, 1991, p. ix). This was the point of departure for the rise of “personal branding” as an economic discourse that fused career advice rhetoric with the logic of brand management.

Prominent works in the personal branding genre exhibit many similarities. Authors usually contend that the “standard” work arrangement has become all but obsolete. Where many commentators see this as cause for concern, personal branding authors instead embrace it as an emancipatory development that can free workers of their dependence on corporate paternalism. This point is evident in the very titles of the genre’s leading works, such as Pamela Slim’s (2010) *Escape from Cubicle Nation: From Corporate Prisoner to Thriving Entrepreneur*. The message is clear: Appropriating corporate marketing practices will enable workers and job seekers to gain greater power within the economy, to advance their own interests in the labor market, and secure a source of personal fulfillment that the Fordist wage-bargain could never provide (Gandini, 2015; Pagis & Ailon, 2017; Vallas & Cummins, 2015; Wee & Brooks, 2010).

Personal branding discourse has become a prominent feature of the labor market, whether in face-to-face settings or in online platforms. In-person events commonly include workshops led by life coaches and career consultants, conferences hosted by motivational speakers and authors, seminars offered by outplacement services (at times as part of severance packages), and trainings provided by state and local governments, attendance at which is sometimes mandatory for receipt of unemployment insurance. The development of digital technologies and social media platforms over the past decade has further reinforced this trend: Workers are encouraged to build their online visibility, curate their presence in social media and job search websites, and promote themselves on social networking sites (Marwick, 2013; Marwick & boyd, 2010; Sharone, 2014), all in addition to presentational strategies to be used in face-to-face interaction.

Many authors are quite explicit about the similarities they posit between the marketing of inanimate products and human employees. But this is not a matter of mere packaging, as Beckwith and Clifford

(2007) make clear in *You, Inc.: The Art of Selling Yourself*, where they insist that a full immersion of the self (one's "being") is necessary if personal brand management is to succeed:

Yes, you sell your skills in this life. You sell what you know and can do. If by using your skills you are able to help enough people, you will become secure and may become rich. Beyond that, however, the most critical thing you sell is literally yourself, your being. People "buy" optimists because they enjoy their company. They "buy" people with integrity because people with integrity do what they say they will. *Like Maytag washing machines, people with integrity can be relied upon.* (p. 7, emphasis in original)

Construing one's being as a brand does not come naturally. It takes practice, training, and tools: Expertise not only in technical skills (e.g., the use of social media) but also in relational or interactional ones (Pagis & Ailon, 2017). Here, the texts are happy to help, offering exercises, drills, and techniques that are sure to do the job. Three examples can be mentioned: (a) Strength–Weakness–Opportunity–and–Threat analyses, here applied not to a business enterprise or department but to one's self as an economic entity; (b) the "Personal Branding Statement," a short, engaging expression of one's distinctive attributes—one's "personal commercial" (Chritton, 2013) that serves as a template for one's in-person and online interactions; and (c) the use of focus groups to test one's branding statement in front of one's friends and associates.

The growing prevalence of personal branding discourse can readily be assessed. Figure 1 presents the results of a LexisNexis search of news media and magazines. It reveals a strong increase in the prevalence of personal branding discourse during the past 30 years. The discourse has shown unrelenting growth in spite of (arguably, because of) severe downturns in the broader economy, which have underscored the need to position oneself in an ever-more turbulent labor market.

This growing phenomenon of personal branding in turn nicely instantiates Foucault's notion of *homo economicus* as an ideal typical form of employee subjectivity. Indeed, texts in the personal branding genre often suggest to their readers that the application of self-branding tactics will open up new avenues for autonomy and empowerment that would not otherwise be available, thus illustrating the "positive" face of power, in Foucault's terms. In addition, the exercises, scripts, and rituals these texts supply can readily be viewed as "technologies of the

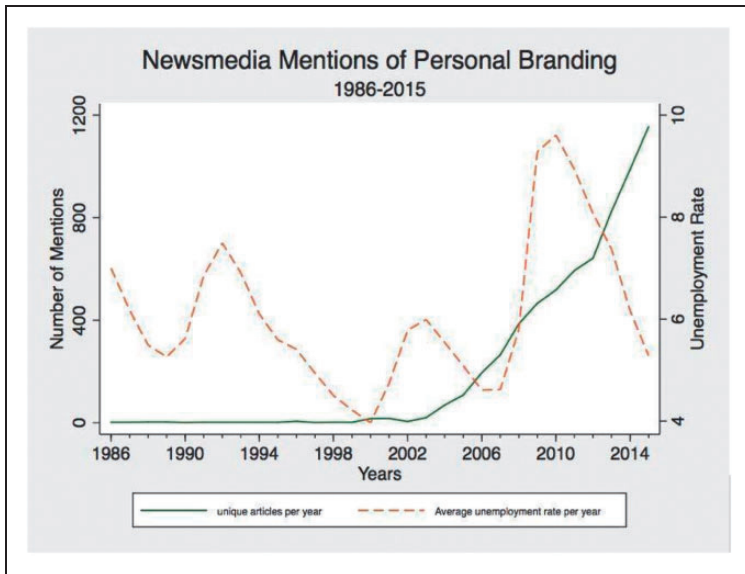


Figure 1. Newsmedia mentions of personal branding, 1986–2015, using LexisNexis.

self” whose outcome explicitly aims to reconfigure individual subjectivity along the lines of the capitalist enterprise (“me, Inc.”; see Lane, 2011). Finally, many of these texts invite the reader to confess the partial, limited, and even deadening nature of their prebranded self, viewing such admissions as a necessary condition for the discovery of the “real,” passionate self that Fordist institutions had concealed. In all these ways, personal branding discourse closely conforms to themes outlined in Foucault’s arguments regarding neoliberal governmentality and the generalization of the enterprise form, all the more so given the growing prevalence of the discourse over the course of the last two decades.

But no textual analysis can suffice to explore the efficacy of this or any discourse (Molyneux, Holton, & Lewis, 2017). Here, it becomes vital to ask how workers and job seekers respond to the discourse of personal branding (see Williams & Connell, 2010). Thus, we return to the research questions mentioned in the introduction: How do precarious workers react to “personal branding” discourse? What social and cultural conditions influence the capacity of workers to resist such discourse?

Methods

To address these questions, we use two sets of data that allow us to gauge the influence of personal branding on the work orientations and identities found among labor force participants in white-collar occupations. As noted, the first study focuses on a single occupation—web journalists—across two geographical settings, while the second study analyzes a single regional setting but allows for variation across multiple white-collar occupations. Both studies were conducted between 2011 and 2014 and aim to understand the meanings that precariously employed workers attach to their positions in the labor market. Both used qualitative methods to explore the social conditions accounting for variations in workers' views. Both relied on grounded theory (Charmaz, 2006) to make sense of their findings. Conjoining the two studies enables us to explore a wide range of responses to personal branding discourse among different kinds of workers facing highly uncertain prospects in the labor market—journalists, whose industry is wracked with structural change and whose positions are intrinsically insecure, and white-collar workers who have encountered economic hardship in the wake of the Great Recession.³

The first study focuses on web journalists, an occupation that underwent major transformation over the past 20 years. Financially, journalism is going through exceptionally dire times. As the news moved online (Boczkowski, 2005), the revenues of print publication fell substantially: between 2000 and 2013, newspapers' advertising revenues decreased by more than half, from \$63.5 billion to \$23 billion (McChesney & Pickard, 2011; Ryfe, 2012). This decline was not compensated for by increased revenues on the digital side (Turow, 2011). As a result, 23,000 newspaper positions were lost between 1989 and 2015; an additional 38,000 magazine jobs disappeared between 2009 and 2014. News websites only created about 5,000 new jobs, a far cry from all the full-time positions that were lost (American Society of News Editors, 2015; Pew Research Center's Project for Excellence in Journalism, 2014).

These broad changes led to a dramatic reconfiguration of journalistic employment in the digital era. For most of the 20th century, journalism as an industry relied predominantly on salaried employment: Most journalists would start their careers with short-term or part-time contracts, before getting a full-time position in a newsroom, perhaps moving once or twice when opportunities arose. Over the past 20 years, however, independent contracting became increasingly prevalent: The number of journalists who freelance and have temporary or part-time positions

has been increasing steadily over the past decades, in the United States and in Europe (Cohen 2015; Marwick, 2013; Weaver, 2007). Note that these recent transformations have affected journalism—online and off-line—in various national contexts, including in the United States and France. Traditionally, American journalism has been analyzed as a market-based system that developed relatively independently of the state (McChesney & Pickard, 2011). In contrast, the development of French journalism has historically depended on state sponsorship, at least since the 1930s. The state monopoly on radio and television ended in the 1980s, but public subsidies are still an important source of financial support of print newspapers and individual journalists—including freelancers, who can receive employment subsidies under a number of specific conditions (Aubert, 2011; Benson, 2013).

The first study thus examined changing attitudes toward work and employment of freelance journalists writing for news websites in Paris and New York. Since freelance web journalists typically live and die according to their ability to generate an Internet presence, they provide an important test regarding the power of personal branding discourse and how it varies depending on the national context. The collection method began with ethnographic fieldwork conducted at five prominent online news organizations in Paris and New York (two online-only web magazines, two online-only news aggregators, and one legacy newspaper that also has a website). This served as a basis for the use of snowball sampling techniques, eventuating in a sample of 101 journalists and bloggers at varying stages of their careers. The U.S. and French interviewees presented rather similar characteristics in terms of age (with an overrepresentation of the 30- to 45-year-old age-group) and number of freelancers: 40% of the sample were freelancers at the time of the interview (about 90% of the web journalists interviewed in the project had been freelancers at some point in their careers). The French journalists were also more likely to have graduated from journalism programs (58% compared with 11% of the Americans), and included a higher proportion of women (40%) than in the United States (25%). These samples are roughly consistent with the sociodemographic characteristics of the U.S. and French journalistic workforces.

The second study targets a sample of educated white-collar employees and job seekers across a range of occupations in the Boston metropolitan area, most of whom have been exposed to relatively high levels of labor market uncertainty since the economic crisis of 2007 to 2008.

Data collection began by recruiting participants through contacts at two local universities, using alumni lists and club memberships.

To maximize the study's ability to capture the effects of labor market precarity, we made a particular effort to include participants who had registered with a university program that was geared to the problems of the long-term unemployed. A modest compensation (a \$20 gift card) was offered as an incentive for participation. The resulting sample yielded 62 semistructured interviews, almost all of whom were college graduates (two held only the associate's degree). Nearly a quarter had postbaccalaureate degrees, including nine with MBA degrees, three with law degrees, and two with PhDs. Interviewees were experienced in a broad range of occupations, with computer programming, technical writing, public relations, human resources, paralegal work, sales, marketing, and nonprofit work among the more prominent occupational fields. While some had strategically valuable skills and qualifications, with experience at the "C-level" (indicating senior positions in a business organization), most had been employed at mid-level positions in the corporate or the nonprofit world.

Despite their relatively high levels of education and experience, evidence of hardship was apparent among these participants. A third of these individuals (20 of the 62) were unemployed when interviewed, and some had been jobless for more than a year. Half the sample was working at nonstandard or contingent jobs, whether at temporary agencies, consulting, or piecing together numerous part-time jobs. Fewer than one in five held full time, "W-2" positions. Although a small handful had received severance packages when laid off, most interviewees shared stories of financial pressure and hardship in one or another form. Some had been compelled to level their career aspirations, as with one woman in her 40s, who commented that "me finding a job that pays 40 grand or more is starting to seem like an unreachable goal." As with the web journalists, this sample provides a useful empirical platform for exploring how workers in precarious labor market positions respond to entrepreneurial ideologies such as personal branding rhetoric.⁴

Findings

The first question we address is how workers and job seekers conceive of or respond to "personal branding" discourse. Here, our data attest to the prevalence of this rhetoric and to a willingness among many of our interviewees to embrace self-branding discourse and techniques as necessary features of their career pursuits.

One sign of the ubiquity of personal branding discourse emerged from the fact that many of our interviewees spontaneously invoked

the term even when asked a generic set of questions about their labor market activities. Such spontaneous uses of the discourse suggested that many interviewees view personal branding as a “natural” feature of any modern economy, or as a set of practices that any job seeker is obliged to master as a matter of course. In the journalism case, freelancers were often intimately convinced that personal branding strategies were helpful to find jobs and to gain a significant presence for their work. A good example is that of John, a 29-year-old freelancer in New York who explained his personal branding efforts with no prompting from the interviewer:

I try to promote myself... *I know the importance of branding* [emphasis added] so I hired a friend to do these business cards for me. I left them everywhere. They're colorful and engaging. It's a way of keeping people interested... And my website is like an online portfolio that allows me to show editors, “hey, look what I'm doing,” but also to show my work to the rest of the world, with social media... So that's a way to get my name out there and my writing out there... for free, of course, but it's exposure... I'm going to conferences, being persistent, meeting contacts, trying to get my ideas out there...

John uses a multifaceted effort at self-branding, relying not only on business cards but also on a personal website, social media, and in-personal networking. The use of social media—especially Twitter—emerged as a constant among virtually all of the web journalists in both New York and in Paris, with many of the interviewees in both cities carefully monitoring their visibility in quantitative terms (Christin, 2017; Marwick, 2013; Revers, 2014). For instance, Patricia, who writes for a political magazine website in New York, shared her frustration at the challenge she encounters in cultivating her own personal brand:

On Twitter I have 2,000 followers... I still don't know how to pass the threshold and be followed massively on Twitter. But now I'm followed by several editors, it's really important. It's a way to build my brand. That's what online journalism is about today... You have a brand and the people who read you follow you. I want to get to that point.

Similar patterns emerged among white-collar workers and job seekers in the Boston data. Here too interviewees commonly invoked branding rhetoric without special prompting and commonly embraced its use. In some cases, interviewees credited self-branding with their career

success. When asked how she initially encountered the discourse of personal branding, Maureen (a web designer now working as an information technology consultant) explained:

That's what gave me the whole idea [her own consulting practice]. I started out when I didn't have a job and I said, 'the only way I'm going to get a job is if I brand myself as an expert.' I sat down and put down my strategy for how I was going to create an online brand for myself. It was a very conscious decision to create a personal brand. That's exactly what I was doing. That's why I was constantly looking at my "klout" score, because it was an indicator to me of how successful I was at creating my personal brand.

Maureen's mention of her "klout" score refers to her use of klout.com, an online platform that captures real-time shifts in one's social media presence, much in the manner of one's stock portfolio. In some cases, interviewees made even more enthusiastic use of personal branding, immersing themselves in the discourse so deeply as to become avatars of its message. Indeed, several of the job seekers led networking groups that actively trained others in the work of personal branding. An example was Beverly, a specialist in educational technology now in her 60s, who said of personal branding:

It's a great thing. And you have to be able to do that, and be able to speak to it, and be able to do it *all the time*. You have to be able to tell *everybody* that that [your personal branding statement] is you . . . It has to come from your hip. If it doesn't, everybody can see right through it. [emphasis added]

To ensure that your personal branding statement is an organic part of you, Beverly repeated:

You have to practice it all the time. You have to practice it to everybody, even when you're at the grocery store. If it's someone you know, you turn around and you tell them your branding statement. You tell them. Because, a lot of people will say "I didn't know you did that! I didn't know that that was you!" And "Oh my gosh! So and so works at such and such." And it can lead you right into that [job opportunity]. So I think it's very important that you do that, that you do it all the time. You have to be able to develop a dialogue with it. A branding statement has to start a dialogue . . . I've helped a lot of other people brand themselves.

Gilda, another interviewee in the Boston case, showed even greater enthusiasm for personal branding and explained that her training in the discourse extended beyond the groups she ran, reaching into her family life:

I got my daughter on LinkedIn when she was 15, so she could begin her personal branding . . . If you go to her LinkedIn page, you'd have to say, 'My God, for 17 years old, look at her personal branding!' So yes, I've been an advocate and a teacher of personal branding . . . I've been helping young people do that as a matter of course for the last decade . . . You have to give the value proposition of you.

Gilda's last comment—"you have to be able to give the value proposition of you"—begins to reveal the mimetic nature of personal branding discourse: Interviews, seminars, and workshops often made use of the same rhetoric as is found in published guides and manuals.

In conducting the interviews, we took care to adopt a neutral orientation toward this phenomenon. Yet when we posed specific questions about personal branding, some interviewees nonetheless expressed a sense of guilt that they had not worked hard enough to craft their personal brands. This is the case of Perry, an unemployed man in his 40s who had much experience as a facilities manager in Boston. When he was read a personal branding excerpt, he immediately agreed with its logic, but then confessed that he had been putting off the effort to perfect his branding statement and needed to redouble his efforts in this regard.

I consider it like work, and something I probably want to avoid. But no one's going to come knocking on my door and give me a job. I have to put the work in [to achieve] a nice, clean, and succinct elevator speech, one that's believable, that sells you . . . If you asked me to give you [my personal branding statement] now, I'd hem and haw. I think that exercises, narrowing it down, and then making people believe it, that's the key, that's the real key. I'm getting there, but I'm not quite there yet.

Similarly, Philip, an attorney in his 50s with his own practice, told us that the interview had "crystallized a lot of things for me" and allowed that "branding myself [better] is what I need to do." We interpret these responses as exhibiting a widely shared view of self-branding as a moral obligation—an instance of what Collinson (2003) has dubbed

“conformist selves,” who fully embraced the marketization of one’s self. Thus personal branding rhetoric does seem to have become a widely institutionalized form of economic discourse, signifying a willingness among many workers and job seekers to adopt an increasingly entrepreneurial posture in relation to their career pursuits. In short, *homo economicus* is no stranger to these interviewees.

Yet this was not the only pattern we found. Alongside such enterprising subjects, we *also* found less fully acquiescent responses, in keeping with Collinson’s (2003) typology. Some interviewees indeed adopted a “dramaturgical” relation to personal branding—that is, a form of strategic compliance that utilized what Goffman (1961) called role distance and what Hochschild (1983) dubbed “surface acting.” Others adopted a posture of opposition or resistance, explicitly refusing, as a matter of principle, the marketization of the self that personal branding implies.

Instances of a strategic or dramaturgical relation toward personal branding were largely confined to the Boston interviewees, several of whom were willing to adopt self-branding rhetoric but who viewed it as a performative maneuver that had no necessary connection to their “real” identities. Instances of this stance seemed especially common among employees who held jobs in public relations, communications, and events planning, who had developed the ability to engage in market-positive behavior while shielding their identities from their outward performances. One example was that of Anna, a public relation staffer in her late 20s, who spoke of having to consciously “turn my interview self ‘off’ and turn my real self ‘on’.” Switching tropes a moment later, she explained that “it’s like a hat that you wear [and can remove].” Another case of dramaturgical compliance was that of Rachel, an administrative assistant, who had carefully crafted one personal branding statement for medical assistant jobs and another, equally elaborate one for positions as a legal assistant (the field in which she was most qualified). When asked which traits she tries to project in interviews, she remarked that “I try to project all the personality traits that have been valued by my previous employers.” When interviewing at a large medical organization, she speaks of her ability to “make the patient feel they are a star in their own performance. It’s catchy.” Some workers in this vein approached personal branding as an extension of their involvement with amateur theater. A customer service representative explained that “It’s like your own little one-man show. You wrote the script, now go perform it.”

Crucially, we also found cases involving “resistant selves” among both groups of interviewees. In the case of journalism, resistant approaches were largely confined to the French freelancers rather than their American counterparts. Indeed, when the French respondents referred to branding discourse, they often did so in ways that expressed a determined refusal of its logic. Marie, a Parisian freelancer in her late 20s, puts the point most concisely:

Networking . . . I’m not very good at it. Once I know people, yeah, I’ll follow them on Twitter and I’ll try to stay in touch, but it’s not systematic. I don’t do *personal branding* [spoken in English]. I’m trying to be myself. But then it’s true that when I post one of my slideshows and tweet: “look at my latest slideshow,” well, I’m selling myself, it’s true that I try to get attention, but I think that it’s natural, I just finished a slideshow, it’s natural, it’s not strategic or mathematical . . .

Here, Marie makes a sharp distinction between “strategic or mathematical” forms of audience-seeking behavior (which she rejects) and a more “natural” and authentic, *non*-commercial pursuit of one’s readership (which she views as simply “trying to be myself”). She acknowledges that her effort to win an audience for her own creative work could be construed as a form of self-branding (“well, I’m selling myself”). But she immediately rejects this way of framing her own practices, which she views as more natural, honest, and thus morally sound. Interestingly, when Marie speaks of self-branding she uses the English phrase, implying that she sees this discourse as an American import that has limited applicability on her home terrain. Overall, and as shown in the comments of John and Patricia quoted earlier, personal branding was more widely accepted among the American journalists, who viewed it as an inevitable feature of freelancing work itself, for better or for worse.

Similarly, the Boston case also revealed many instances of a refusal or rejection of the discourse as such. In some cases, interviewees invoked a sharp distinction between commercial products and living human beings. One example is that of Francesca, a woman in her 40s with a PhD in molecular biology:

I find it extremely hard to create a brand for a person, as opposed to a service . . . and overall I’m quite turned off by the infusion of marketing concepts into the job search field . . . I just hate it. Maybe that’s just my scientific background.

Similarly, Catherine, the former director of a mental health agency, now unemployed for months, responded to an instance of personal branding rhetoric by saying this:

It's junk. It's just words . . . As an employer, if somebody's resume was full of all this marketing hyperbole on the top of their resume . . . [presenting] their skills [as] if it was an advertisement, I'd probably laugh. I might look at their resume anyway but I would think it would take away from my feeling about them as a professional.

Those who resisted or refused personal branding rhetoric sometimes spoke with disdain of the “false face” that branding discourse required users to adopt, arguing that personal brands seem “fake” or “PR-ish,” and referred to it as “business-speak” or “internet slang.”

It is important to note that in many cases, we found evidence that resistance toward personal branding was not a static response but was instead subject to change over time, especially in light of the labor market uncertainty to which workers were exposed. Numerous instances emerged in which interviewees spoke of an initial refusal of personal branding but eventually embraced its dictates out of sheer desperation. For instance, Wanda, a paralegal employee in her mid-50s, initially refused to conceive of herself as needing a personal brand, but after a long spell of unemployment, and after feeling her way through various workshops, eventually embraced personal branding so fully that she now speaks of her ongoing effort to “incorporate everything I can, everything that's useful, in the hopes of bettering and developing me, my brand.” Similarly, an unemployed engineer who made clear his strong objection to personal branding eventually closed the interview by expressing his willingness to surrender any critical stance, if doing so would enable him to find secure employment.

Discussion

The evidence presented thus far allows us to make two general observations. First, familiarity with personal branding is indeed widespread. Many of the web journalists we interviewed find personal branding to be a useful means of audience-promotion, and this stance is also quite pronounced among the broader sample of Boston white-collar employees. Alongside this finding, however, is a second point: that interviewees respond to entrepreneurial discourse in a multiplicity of ways, defying characterization in simple or uniform terms. While people like John

(New York journalist), Beverly (educational technology specialist) or Maureen (information technology consultant) all neatly fit the profile of the “conformist” or enterprising self, individuals such as Marie (Paris-based journalist), Francesca (PhD in molecular biology), and Catherine (health-care administrator) clearly matched what Collinson (2003) dubs the “resistant” type. The “dramaturgical” category, too, was evident, as in the cases of Rachel and Anna (both performing routine administrative work in public-facing occupations), and to some extent Marie. The question then becomes one of identifying the sources of variation in employee responses to personal branding rhetoric. Although many factors are doubtless at work, our data point to three important factors, involving the nationally specific cultural repertoires to which workers are exposed, the occupational norms that workers have experienced and internalized, and the level of labor market insecurity that workers have had to confront. We discuss these in turn.

Cross-National Differences

Our ability to compare workers’ response toward personal branding discourse in the American and French context enables us to identify the influences that shape subjective orientations toward work and the self in the two countries. Here, our data clearly indicate cross-national differences as far as web journalists are concerned: Overall, the French freelancers are less likely to engage in personal branding while their American counterparts see self-branding as a useful tool with which to engage in the audience-seeking behavior their occupations “naturally” require. The question, then, is why this cross-national difference occurs.

One obvious approach points to the structural differences that accompany employment in the two different societies. In theory, French freelancers enjoy access to a host of social insurance benefits—wage subsidies in particular, and other labor protections as well—that are denied American freelancers. Arguably, the availability of material benefits or subsidies from the French state might allow freelancers to enjoy greater distance from necessity. But this account is not easily squared with our data, as few of the French freelancers in this study had availed themselves of state-provided benefits, either because of their reluctance to satisfy the complex bureaucratic protocols that are required or a lack of knowledge regarding their actual eligibility. This finding suggests that normative constructs have exerted a relatively autonomous effect on the freelancers’ views. In other words, the

material resources provided by the French state seem here less consequential than the nationally specific “cultural repertoires” (Alvesson & Willmott, 2002; Lamont & Thévenot, 2000, p. 8) that freelancers are able to invoke. Specifically, French freelancers seem to rely on discourses involving “civic solidarity,” framing their audience-seeking efforts in terms of authenticity but also as a contribution to the public good (Lamont & Thévenot, 2000). Self-branding is also often viewed as an expression of American capitalism, as suggested in Marie’s switch to English when using this term, which further supports this idea of a cultural refusal. For their part, the American freelancers have little access to such a cultural repertoire imbued with civic solidarity and are far more prone to view their audience-seeking behavior in marketized terms.

It is interesting to note, however, that the two groups appear to manage their occupational choices and daily decisions in highly similar ways. French freelancers *do* work in a highly competitive marketplace—that is, they too must promote the visibility of their work—yet they refuse to define this promotional work in instrumental or market-based terms, whereas American journalists have no such hesitation. The question arises, then, as to whether the antimarket posture of the French freelancers exhibits an internal tension between its actual behavior on the one hand and its discursive framing on the other (Jerolmack & Khan, 2014). As the French state encounters pressures to embrace neoliberal ideas, and the French labor market increasingly moves in the direction of flexibilization (Abdelnour & Lambert, 2014), antimarket discourses may become harder to sustain over time—for journalists and others as well.

Occupational Norms

Although we find important cross-national differences in cultural orientations toward work and self, we also find similarities across national boundaries. Importantly, there are groups of American workers who, like the French freelancers, refuse market norms. This posture of resistance was especially pronounced among U.S. employees whose backgrounds exposed them to occupation-based norms encouraging them to expect autonomy from market imperatives (Thornton & Ocasio, 1999; Turco, 2012). Recall the cases of Catherine (the mental health administrator who said she would “laugh” at instances of personal branding by job candidates), and Francesca (the molecular biologist who “hated” market-based views of people, a view she attributed

to her training in natural science). Similar views were expressed by others who had been employed in such professional occupations as technical writers, archivists, graphic designers, and academics. What unites the French and the Americans holding these critical views is their shared conviction that the assertion of an autonomous self at work—a practice which personal branding appears to threaten (but see Pagis & Ailon, 2017)—is a necessary condition for the maintenance of one's dignity as a professional employee.

Interestingly, however, there were also numerous instances of employees whose employment in professional occupations did *not* foster such a counter-discourse. The American freelance journalists, who pursue professional distinction precisely through the market for page views and social media popularity, are one case in point. But in the Boston data, we also found that lawyers who maintained their own practices saw value in market-based norms, as was true with engineers and especially those who had been trained and employed as programmers and computer scientists. Indeed, technical professionals with expertise in the field of information technology—including many with successful stints as consultants—were disproportionately supportive of personal branding as an orientation toward work and self. Arguably, this gulf between subjects valuing professional autonomy from the market on the one hand, and their counterparts who are more fully (and willingly) immersed in market-based practices on the other, may stem from the wider division between two distinct fractions of the “new class,” as Gouldner (1979) conceived it.

Exposure to Labor Market Uncertainty

A third observation is that specifically material influences, in addition to cultural patterns established at the national and occupational levels, also shaped employees' orientations toward career and self. Here, we refer to the disciplinary effects of labor market uncertainty. Specifically, prolonged exposure to economic precarity exerted significant effects on workers' views, albeit differentially so in France and the United States. As we have seen, French freelancers who held uncertain positions in the field of journalism nonetheless remained highly critical of self-branding rhetoric. Among the American workers who were exposed to precarious conditions of employment, however, such a critical stance came to seem like a luxury that interviewees could not—or no longer—afford.

This last point was most pronounced in the data gathered from the Boston participants, as employees who were less exposed to precarious

forms of employment seemed somewhat more likely to question or resist self-branding rhetoric than did those in more contingent or precarious positions. Conversely, interviewees who had been exposed to longer spells of labor market uncertainty seemed consistently more amenable to self-branding practices. These subjects—some of whom faced uncertain situations with their homes, credit card debt, or health-care expenses—made clear that they were in no position to question the nature of the career advice they encountered, and even asked the interviewer for information about *pro bono* branding coaches. As noted, exposure to economic precarity also inclined the Boston interviewees to shift their views over time, relinquishing any initial skepticism toward self-branding rhetoric and exchanging it for a more acquiescent stance. Little evidence of this “disciplining” effect emerged among the French interviewees, suggesting that the erosion of the “standard” work arrangement exerts different effects on actors’ identities depending on the institutional context at hand.⁵

Conclusion

This article began as an effort to address two deficiencies that have limited recent sociological efforts to explain the proliferation of precarious work: The field’s relative inattention to ideological or discursive influences in legitimating precarious work arrangements, and the relatively undertheorized state of research in this field. In an effort to address these deficiencies, our article has adopted a two-pronged strategy. In theoretical terms, we have appealed to the work of Michel Foucault, whose theory of governmentality provides a useful lens through which to study how individual subjectivities reinforce—or not—specific types of political and economic arrangements. In more empirical terms, we have used data drawn from two distinct yet complementary studies of precariously employed workers: freelance journalists in New York and Paris and white-collar workers in Boston. Using this data, we have examined the meanings workers attach to an increasingly influential form of economic discourse: “personal branding,” an outgrowth of the career advice genre. Our findings have implications both for this particular form of discourse and for theoretical thinking regarding neoliberalism more generally.

Our data reveal that entrepreneurial discourse has indeed become a ubiquitous feature of the economic landscape for many workers, much as Foucauldian theory expects. Respondents in both national contexts seemed highly familiar with personal branding rhetoric, often even using

it without any prompting from the interviewer. Personal branding discourse seemed especially potent in the U.S. context—both among the freelance journalists in New York and the white-collar workers in Boston. Although not the only response to personal branding discourse, conformity or consent to its logic—and thus to the notion of the “enterprising self”—was the predominant posture that many workers assumed. Here, we see at least partial warrant for the Foucauldian expectation regarding *homo economicus*. Facing economic precarity, many workers do exhibit pressure to adopt forms of subjectivity that construe their career horizons and work identities as objects to which corporate marketing techniques must be applied. Advice regarding the application of corporate techniques to one’s self are by no means limited to the pages of *Branding for Dummies* and other personal branding texts; they have been adopted in everyday life by workers and job seekers seeking to defend or advance their careers. Indeed, the argument can be made that personal branding discourse has grown even more pervasive since our data were collected, as social media like Twitter and Instagram have become almost ubiquitous platforms on which the enterprising self routinely performs.⁶

Yet we *also* document variation in the postures that actors assume. Our data suggest that enterprising or conformist selves do exist but sit alongside less conformist forms of subjectivity—dramaturgical and resistant selves—which themselves vary depending on the institutional conditions to which workers are exposed. Three such conditions emerged in our analysis: those stemming from the nationally specific cultural repertoires (Lamont & Thévenot, 2000; Mijs et al., 2016); the occupational norms workers have experienced at work; and the degree of material precarity they have endured in their labor market situations. Interestingly, in the United States, the group that seemed most resistant to entrepreneurial discourse included workers who had been steeped in professional settings that favored or even required autonomy from the market. This finding aligns with a number of similar results, such as reported by Turco (2012) and Cornfield (2015), who found important instances in which occupational norms and discourses enabled workers to resist the application of market logics to their work or labor market situations (cf. Kellogg, 2011). This point suggests that the maintenance of occupational autonomy has effects that reach beyond the workplace itself, in that it provides important cultural resources that workers need if they are to envision alternatives to an ever-more neoliberalized world.

At a more theoretical level, the question emerges as to the value that Foucauldian theory holds for sociologists seeking to understand the

precarization of work more generally. Much of Foucault's (1979) own work proceeds on the assumption that the emergence of particular types of subjectivity can best be viewed as an "effect of certain forms of power" (p. 29). Foucault applied this insight to multiple historical contexts, seeking to understand the micropolitical rituals through which distinct regimes of selfhood arise. Composing one's personal branding statement or practicing one's performance in front of a mirror—rituals that are often suggested in the personal branding literature—constitute precisely such technologies and may well have subtle yet important effects on the modern worker's identity, fostering a more acquiescent posture toward neoliberal practices than would otherwise be the case. One contribution of Foucauldian theory, then, is that it sensitizes us to the types of interpellation that arise in given contexts (Althusser, 1971), and that may underpin the emergence of newly emergent forms of subjectivity.⁷

A second strength of Foucauldian theory stems from Foucault's (2008) own discussion of human capital theory (Becker, 1964/1993). As noted, sociological approaches toward human capital theory have usually engaged this approach as a scientific prediction to be confirmed or refuted (e.g., Lin & Tomaskovic-Devey, 2013). In contrast, Foucault suggests that the "truth" lurking within human capital theory lies not in its empirical validity (or lack thereof), but in its cultural or normative power, which he believed would grow over time. In his view, human capital theory is but one element within a system of governance in which power is increasingly invested in economic apparatuses and the forms of subjectivity they conjure. Foucault reasoned that a culture of "enterprise" was likely to emerge (du Gay, 1996) that would individualize actors, foster a view of the self as a revenue-generating enterprise, and define this marketized condition as a source of agency, autonomy, and empowerment. Arguably, this individualizing discourse is one of the main reasons why the precariously employed have remained relatively quiescent (Boltanski & Chiapello, 2005).

Yet a third and final point that emerges from this study concerns the existence of variations in responses to neoliberal or entrepreneurial rhetoric. Here, Foucauldian theory leaves us with a number of unresolved issues. For one thing, Foucault and his followers have only rarely thought to consider cross-national variations in the processes they sketch. Yet, as we have seen, variations in nationally specific cultural repertoires can hardly be overlooked. Indeed, neglect of such repertoires may even impede scholarly analysis. It may be that American cultural repertoires have so deeply naturalized entrepreneurial language that

U.S. scholars have found little reason to problematize the enterprising self. Perhaps this is why critical analysis of “enterprise culture” has largely emanated from the United Kingdom, owing to the emergence of the forms of political contention which the Thatcher revolution provoked (Harvey, 2005; Vallas & Cummins, 2015). Absent such explicit struggles over neoliberal practices and social policies, the entrepreneurial norms that impinge on the self may remain taken for granted, even by scholars seeking to grasp the marketization process.

It is not difficult to find evidence that neoliberal thinking has begun to impinge on employee identity in many national contexts, even (or especially) in the wake of economic crisis.⁸ Many instances can be found in which public policy in the European Union has applied enterprising discourse in ways that many Americans would find familiar. In Germany, for example, the Hartz reforms of 2002 contained an important revision dubbed *Ich AG* (“Me, Inc.”), as part of the government’s explicit effort to implement an entrepreneurial culture of innovation. Similarly, a study of life coaches in Finland (Makinen, 2014) found that entrepreneurial discourse has proved highly popular even in this Nordic nation. Evidence of neoliberal discourse has also found expression in the notion of the *auto-entrepreneur* in France (Abdelnour & Lambert, 2014). The question—which Foucault left in an ambiguous state—is whether nationally specific structures and cultural repertoires will equip workers with the capacity to modify, challenge, or refuse such neoliberalizing discourses. As web-based platforms such as Twitter and Instagram proliferate across national boundaries, enabling or requiring participants to engage in audience-promotion and identity work of various sorts—but always constrained by the platform’s features—what meanings will workers and job seekers attach to such activities? What cultural resources will they need to resist the entrepreneurial definitions and practices they increasingly confront? And what alternative conceptions of work and self must emerge if effective forms of counter-conduct are to take root? Such questions remain to be addressed to better understand how work arrangements are being transformed in an increasingly globalized and dematerialized employment era.

Acknowledgment

The authors wish to acknowledge the generous and supportive commentary of Woody Powell, Heather Haveman, Cat Turco, and the anonymous reviewers of *Work and Occupations*. Any remaining flaws are of course entirely our own.

Declaration of Conflicting Interests

The authors declared no potential conflicts of interest with respect to the research, authorship, and/or publication of this article.

Funding

The authors received no financial support for the research, authorship, and/or publication of this article.

Notes

1. There are important similarities between Weber and Foucault. Both stressed the role of formal knowledge or expertise in the exercise of domination. Both adopted a wary view toward Marxism and toward science as a source of human emancipation. And both placed great emphasis on the subjective orientations that actors embrace. Arguably, Weber's *Protestant Ethic* constitutes a discourse analysis that anticipates many themes which Foucault was later to develop along novel lines. On the relation between Weber and Foucault, see O'Neill (1986).
2. In his *History of Sexuality* (1978), Foucault initially drew a distinction between Eastern and Western knowledge about sex (juxtaposing *ars erotica* in the East to *sexualis scientia* in the West), but quickly abandoned this distinction as unfounded.
3. The two studies began independently, with somewhat different goals in mind: The U.S. and French journalism focused largely on digital transformation in different national contexts, while the Boston study aimed to understand the economic discourses found among the precarious unemployed. As we discussed our respective findings, the results seemed so congruent as to warrant their combination. The comparison between the two cases, we believe, enables us to make a broader set of comparisons that either project alone can achieve. Yet this comparative approach also comes with limitations. In particular, the design of the two studies differs. In one case (the U.S. and France study), the project was ethnographic and started with observations of five newsrooms, complemented by semistructured interviews with journalists working for these newsrooms. In the second case (the Boston study), the project was interview based and more explicitly focused on workers' experience of precarity, which resulted in a different sampling method and interview grid. Despite these differences, which the methods section details, we found enough similarities between our two sets of data to develop a fruitful comparison in this article (for a recent study adopting a similar comparative design, see Lara-Millan & Van Cleve, 2016).
4. In both sets of data, the overwhelming majority of the interviewees were White, reflecting the relatively privileged channels through which participants were recruited. This point limits the study's ability to tease out the differential experiences of historically excluded groups, which cannot be addressed in the current study.

5. Even here, we suspect that a subtle interplay exists between economic and cultural influences. Lacking an antimarket cultural repertoire, precariously employed subjects in Boston were understandably more susceptible to self-branding discourse. Armed with a more pronounced antimarket outlook, the French freelancers responded to their precarious positions with a greater degree of independence and resistance.
6. Although our data reveal few if any gender differences, analysis of platforms such as Instagram might suggest otherwise, as many aspiring models use Instagram to post photographs of themselves wearing designer goods that are “tagged” (or labeled), doing so in an effort to gain prominence and marketability for their personal brands.
7. This is a point of difference between Weber and Foucault. Although the former paid little explicit attention to individuality, the latter viewed individuality as itself a technology, the deployment of which played an important role in the operation of power within civil society. This is an important difference between our approach to personal branding and the more Weberian approach adopted by Biggart (1989), which uses a Weberian perspective.
8. LexisNexis data (not shown) indicate that the traffic in “personal branding” rhetoric was initially limited to the United States but has increasingly spread across national lines.

References

- Abdelnour, S., & Lambert, A. (2014). L'entreprise de soi, un nouveau mode de gestion politique des classes populaires? [The enterprise of self, a new mode of political management of the popular classes?] *Genèses*, 2(95), 27–48.
- Althusser, L. (1971). *Ideology and ideological state apparatuses (notes towards an investigation)*. *Lenin and philosophy and other essays*. London, England: Verso.
- Alvesson, M., & Willmott, H. (2002). Identity regulation as organizational control: Producing the appropriate individual. *Journal of Management Studies*, 39, 619–644.
- American Society of News Editors. (2015). *ASNE Newsroom Census*. Retrieved from <http://asne.org/content.asp?contentid=121>
- Aubert, C. (2011). *La figure du pigiste comme forme de mobilisation de la main-d'oeuvre: Le cas de la presse écrite française* [The figure of the freelancer as a form of mobilization of the workforce: The case of the French written press]. Sarrebruck, Germany: Éditions Universitaires Européennes.
- Bauman, Z. (2000). *Liquid modernity*. Cambridge, England: Polity.
- Beck, U. (1992). *The risk society: Toward a new modernity*. Thousand Oaks, CA: Sage.
- Beck, U. (2000). *The brave new world of work*. Cambridge, England: Polity.

- Becker, G. (1964/1993). *Human capital: A theoretical and empirical analysis, with special reference to education* (3rd ed.). Chicago, IL: The University of Chicago Press.
- Beckwith, H., & Clifford, C. (2007). *You, inc.: The art of selling yourself*. New York, NY: Warner Business Books.
- Behrent, M. C. (2016). Conclusion: The strange failure (and peculiar success) of Foucault's project. In D. Zamora & M. C. Behrent (Eds.), *Foucault and neoliberalism* (pp. 176–187). Cambridge, England: Polity.
- Benson, R. (2013). *Shaping immigration news: A French-American comparison*. Cambridge, England: Cambridge University Press.
- Biggart, N. W. (1983). Rationality, meaning, and self-management: Success manuals, 1950–1980. *Social Problems*, 30(3), 298–311.
- Biggart, N. W. (1989). *Charismatic capitalism: Direct selling organizations in America*. Chicago, IL: University of Chicago Press.
- Boczkowski, P. J. (2005). *Digitizing the news: Innovation in online newspapers*. Cambridge, England: MIT Press.
- Boltanski, L., & Chiapello, E. (2005). *The new spirit of capitalism*. London, England: Verso.
- Bronfenbrenner, K., & Luce, S. (2004). *The changing nature of corporate global restructuring: The impact of production shifts on jobs in the US, China, and around the globe*. Washington, DC: US–China Economic and Security Review Commission.
- Burchell, G. (1996). Liberal government and techniques of the self. In A. Barry, T. Osborne & N. Rose (Eds.), *Foucault and political reason* (pp. 19–73). Chicago, IL: University of Chicago Press.
- Charmaz, K. (2006). *Constructing grounded theory: A practical guide through qualitative analysis*. Thousand Oaks, CA: Sage.
- Christin, A. (2017). Counting clicks. Quantification and variation in web journalism in the United States and France. *American Journal of Sociology*.
- Chritton, S. (2013). *Personal branding for dummies*. Hoboken, NJ: Wiley and Sons.
- Cohen, N. S. (2015). Entrepreneurial journalism and the precarious state of media work. *South Atlantic Quarterly*, 114(3), 513–533.
- Collins, J. L. (2003). *Threads: Gender, labor, and power in the global apparel industry*. Chicago, IL: University of Chicago Press.
- Collinson, D. (2003). Identities and insecurities: Selves at work. *Organization*, 10, 527–547.
- Cornfield, D. B. (2015). *Beyond the beat. Musicians building community in Nashville*. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press.
- Davidson, A. I. (2007). Introduction. In M. Sellenart (Ed.), *Michel Foucault, Security, territory, population: Lectures at the Collège de France, 1977–1978* (pp. xviii–xxxiv). New York, NY: Palgrave.
- du Gay, P. (1996). *Consumption and identity at work*. Thousand Oaks, CA: Sage.

- Fligstein, N., & Shin, T. (2007). Shareholder value and the transformation of the U.S. economy, 1984–2000. *Sociological Forum*, 22(4), 399–424.
- Foucault, M. (1978). *The history of sexuality* (Vol. 1). New York, NY: Vintage.
- Foucault, M. (1979). *Discipline and punish: Birth of the prison*. New York, NY: Vintage.
- Foucault, M. (1982). The subject and power. In H. L. Dreyfus & P. Rabinow (Eds.), *Michel Foucault: Beyond structuralism and hermeneutics* (2nd ed., pp. 208–228). Chicago, IL: University of Chicago Press.
- Foucault, M. (1988). *Madness and civilization: The birth of the asylum*. New York, NY: NYL Vintage.
- Foucault, M. (1993). About the beginnings of the hermeneutics of the self: Two lectures at Dartmouth. *Political Theory*, 21, 198–227. (Foreword by Mark Blasius).
- Foucault, M. (2007). *Security, territory, population: Lectures at the College de France, 1977-1978*. New York, NY: Palgrave.
- Foucault, M. (2008). *The birth of biopolitics: Lectures at the College de France, 1978-79*. New York, NY: Palgrave.
- Gandini, A. (2015). Digital work: Self-branding and social capital in the free-lance knowledge economy. *Marketing Theory*, 16(1), 123–141.
- Gershon, I. (2011). Neoliberal agency. *Current Anthropology*, 52(4), 537–555.
- Giddens, A. (1991). *Modernity and self-identity*. Palo Alto, CA: Stanford University Press.
- Goffman, E. (1961). *Encounters: Two studies in the sociology of interaction*. New York, NY: Bobbs-Merrill.
- Gordon, C. (1991). Governmental rationality: An introduction. In G. Burchell, C. Gordon & P. Miller (Eds.), *The Foucault effect: Studies in governmentality* (pp. 1–52). Chicago, IL: University of Chicago Press.
- Gouldner, A. W. (1979). *The future of intellectuals and the rise of the new class*. New York, NY: Palgrave.
- Harvey, D. (2005). *A brief history of neo-liberalism*. New York, NY: Oxford.
- Ho, K. (2009a). Disciplining investment bankers, disciplining the economy: Wall street's institutional culture of crisis and the downsizing of American corporations. *American Anthropologist*, 111, 177–189.
- Ho, K. (2009b). *Liquidated: An ethnography of wall street*. Durham, NC: Duke University Press.
- Hochschild, A. (1983). *The managed heart: The commercialization of human feeling*. Berkeley, CA: University of California Press.
- Hollister, M. (2011). Employment stability in the U.S. labor market: Rhetoric versus reality. *Annual Review of Sociology*, 37, 305–324.
- Jamson, F. (1991). *Post-modernism: The cultural logic of late capitalism*. Durham, NC: Duke University Press.
- Jerolmack, C., & Khan, S. (2014). Talk is cheap: Ethnography and the attitudinal fallacy. *Sociological Methods & Research*, 43(2), 1–36.

- Kalleberg, A. (2011). *Good jobs, bad jobs: The rise of polarized and precarious employment systems in the United States, 1970s to 2000s*. New York, NY: Russell Sage Foundation.
- Kalleberg, A. L. (2009). Precarious work, insecure workers: Employment relations in transition. *American Sociological Review*, 74(1), 1–22.
- Kalleberg, A. L., & Vallas S. P. (2017). Probing precarious work: Theory, research, and politics. In A. L. Kalleberg & S. Vallas (Eds.), *Precarious work: Causes, characteristics, and consequences* (Research in the Sociology of Work, Vol. 31). Bingley, England: Emerald.
- Katz, L. F., & Krueger, A. B. (2016). *The rise and nature of alternative work arrangements in the United States, 1995-2015*. Retrieved from http://krueger.princeton.edu/sites/default/files/akrueger/files/katz_krueger_cws_-_march_29_20165.pdf
- Kellogg, K. C. (2011). *Challenging operations: Medical reform and resistance in surgery*. Chicago, IL: University of Chicago Press.
- Knights, D. (2016). The grand refusal? Struggling with alternative Foucauldian inspired approaches to resistance at work. In D. Courpasson & S. P. Vallas (Eds.), *The sage handbook of resistance* (pp. 98–120). Thousand Oaks, CA: Sage.
- Lamont, M., Beljean, S., & Clair, M. (2014). What is missing? *Socio Economic Review*, 12, 573–608.
- Lamont, M., & Thévenot, L. (Eds.). (2000). *Rethinking comparative cultural sociology: Repertoires of evaluation in France and the United States*. Cambridge, England: Cambridge University Press.
- Lane, C. (2011). *A company of one: Insecurity, independence, and the new world of white collar unemployment*. Ithaca, NY: ILR/Cornell.
- Lara-Millan, A., & Van Cleve, N. G. (2016). Inter-organizational utility of welfare stigma in the criminal justice system. *Criminology*, 55(1), 59–84.
- Lash, S., & Urry, J. (1987). *The end of organized capitalism*. Madison, WI: University of Wisconsin Press.
- Lemke, T. (2001). “The birth of bio-politics”: Michel Foucault’s lecture at the Collège de France on neo-liberal governmentality. *Economy and Society*, 30(2), 190–207.
- Lin, K.-H., & Tomaskovic-Devey, D. (2013). Financialization and U.S. income inequality, 1970–2008. *American Journal of Sociology*, 118(5), 1284–1329.
- Locke, R., & Thelen, K. (1995). Apples and oranges revisited: Contextualized comparisons and the study of comparative labor politics. *Politics and Society*, 23(3), 337–367.
- Makinen, K. (2014). The individualization of class: A case of working life coaching. *The Sociological Review*, 62(4), 8221–8842.
- Marwick, A. E. (2013). *Status update: Celebrity, publicity and branding in the social media age*. New Haven, CT: Yale University Press.

- Marwick, A. E., & boyd, D. (2010). I tweet honestly, I tweet passionately: Twitter users, context collapse, and the imagined audience. *New Media and Society*, 12(1), 114–133.
- McChesney, R. W., & Pickard, V. (Eds). (2011). *Will the last reporter please turn out the lights: The collapse of journalism and what can be done to fix it*. New York, NY: The New Press.
- McGee, M. (2005). *Self-help, Inc: Makeover culture in American life*. London, England: Oxford.
- McNay, L. (2009). Self as enterprise: Dilemmas of control and resistance in Foucault's *The Birth of Biopolitics*. *Theory Culture Society*, 26(6), 55–77.
- Mijs, J. J. B., Bakhtiari, E., & Lamont, M. (2016). Neoliberalism and symbolic boundaries in Europe: Global diffusion, local context, regional variation. *Socius: Sociological Research for a Dynamic World*, 2, 1–8.
- Molyneux, L., Holton, A., & Lewis, S. C. (2017). How journalists engage in branding on Twitter: Individual, organizational, and institutional levels. *Information, Communication, and Society*. Advance online publication. Retrieved from <http://dx.doi.org/10.1080/1369118X.2017.1314532>
- O'Neill, J. (1986). The disciplinary society: From Weber to Foucault. *British Journal of Sociology*, 37(1), 42–60.
- Pagis, M., & Ailon, G. (2017). The paradoxes of self-branding: An analysis of consultants' professional web pages. *Work and Occupations*, 44(3), 243–267.
- Peck, J. (2010). *Constructions of neoliberal reason*. Oxford, England: Oxford University Press.
- Pew Research Center's Project for Excellence in Journalism. (2014). *The State of the News Media 2014*. Retrieved from <http://www.journalism.org/packages/state-of-the-news-media-2014/>
- Pugh, A. (2015). *The tumbleweed society*. New York, NY: Oxford.
- Revers, M. (2014). The Twitterization of news making: Transparency and journalism professionalism. *Journal of Communication*, 64(5), 806–826.
- Ryfe, D. M. (2012). *Can journalism survive? An inside look at American newsrooms*. London, England: Polity.
- Schor, J. B., Fitzmaurice, C., Attwood-Charles, W., Carfagna, L. B., & Poteat, E. D. (2016). Paradoxes of openness and distinction in the sharing economy. *Poetics*, 54, 66–81.
- Sharone, O. (2014). *Flawed system, flawed self: Job searching and unemployment experiences*. Chicago, IL: University of Chicago Press.
- Slim, P. (2010). *Escape from cubicle nation: From corporate prisoner to thriving entrepreneur*. New York, NY: Penguin.
- Smith, V. (2001). *Crossing the great divide: Worker risk and opportunity in the new economy*. Ithaca NY: Cornell/ILR.
- Smith, V. (2010). Enhancing employability: Human, cultural, and social capital in an era of turbulent unpredictability. *Human Relations*, 63, 279–300.
- Thompson, P., & Ackroyd, S. (1995). All quiet on the workplace front? A critique of recent trends in British industrial sociology. *Sociology*, 33(1), 47–67.

- Thornton, P., & Ocasio, W. (1999). Institutional logics and the historical contingency of power in organizations: Executive succession in the higher education publishing industry, 1958–1990. *American Journal of Sociology*, 105, 801–843.
- Turco, C. (2012). Difficult decoupling: Employee resistance to the commercialization of personal settings. *American Journal of Sociology*, 118(2), 380–419.
- Turow, J. (2011). *The daily you. How the new advertising industry is defining your identity and your worth*. New Haven, CT: Yale University Press.
- Vallas, S. P., & Cummins, E. (2015). Personal branding and identity norms in the popular business press: Enterprise culture in an age of precarity. *Organization Studies*, 3, 293–320.
- Vallas, S. P., & Hill, A. (2012). Conceptualizing power in organizations. *Research in the Sociology of Organizations*, 34, 165–197.
- Weaver, D. H. (2007). *The American journalist in the 21st Century: U.S. news people at the Dawn of a new millennium*. Mahwah, NJ: L. Erlbaum Associates.
- Wee, L., & Brooks, A. (2010). Personal branding and the commodification of reflexivity. *Cultural Sociology*, 4(1), 45–62.
- Wernick, A. (1991). *Promotional culture: Advertising, ideology, and symbolic expression*. London, England: Sage.
- Western, B., & Rosenfeld, J. (2011). Unions, norms, and the rise in US wage inequality. *American Sociological Review*, 76(4), 513–537.
- Williams, C. L., & Connell, C. (2010). Looking good and sounding right: Aesthetic labor and social inequality in the retail industry. *Work and Occupations*, 37(3), 349–377.

Author Biographies

Steven P. Vallas teaches sociology at the Northeastern University in Boston. He has written and edited on various facets of work organizations, emphasizing the tensions and contradictions that emerge among classes and groups when workplaces undergo rapid structural change. His current work focuses on the shifting meaning of work in an age of flexible capitalism.

Angèle Christin is an assistant professor of communication at the Stanford University. She studies how digital technologies and algorithms affect work practices, careers, and organizational forms. Her book project examines the growing influence of audience metrics (*clicks*) in web journalism in the United States and France.